

Chicago Tribune



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CASH CROPS, HIDDEN COSTS



A MISSING LINK IN THE CHAIN

A lack of middlemen between Illinois farmers and consumers limits the market for local fruits and vegetables. As climate change makes the problem worse, grassroots groups are getting to work

By Karina Atkins | Chicago Tribune

Marty Travis sends an email to small grocers and chefs across Illinois every Friday morning advertising fresh produce, dairy and meats available from small farms in central Illinois.

In late May, purple asparagus from 19 x 1950 Family Farm in Benson, romaine from Bland Family Farm in Jacksonville and radishes from Diamond's Homestead in Decatur were all on the menu. No fruit was ripe yet.

Restaurants, corporate kitchens, family-owned markets and food banks place their orders before noon Monday. On Tuesday, farmers haul their goods to Travis' warehouse in Fairbury, Illinois, until it's full to the brim. These goods are loaded into refrigerated trucks and delivered to the customers Wednesday.

Last year, nearly 120 farmers provided just under 1 million pounds of food to Frontera Grill in Chicago, Midwest Food Bank in Peoria and nearly 90 places in between.

Travis has been building a local food system from the ground up for the last two decades, serving as a middleman between specialty crop farmers and nearby markets. It's a connection that's largely missing in Illinois, where farmland is dominated by corn and soybeans.

The Tribune is launching a series of special reports analyzing the hurdles many farmers face in trying to be good stewards of the land as climate change intensifies. While farmers report that rising rents, lack of crop insurance and labor shortages deter them from growing anything else, they say their biggest barrier to growing fruits and vegetables is that there isn't a streamlined way to get them to market.

The fifth largest agricultural state has largely relied on others for fruits and vegetables that go into salads and smoothies. On a late May trip to a Mariano's in Chicago, the asparagus was from Mexico and the romaine, radishes and raspberries were from California.

Marty Travis loads yogurts, cheeses, greens and Swiss chard into the vehicle of Reggie Stewart of Runaway Buckers farm after Stewart bought bratwurst and pork chops at the Down at the Farms distribution hub in Fairbury, Ill., on April 29. In 2004, Travis started Down at the Farms to serve as a middleman between specialty crop farmers and nearby markets and restaurants. Last year, through Down at the Farms, nearly 120 farmers provided just under 1 million pounds of food to Frontera Grill in Chicago, Midwest Food Bank in Peoria and nearly 90 places in between.

ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

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But as climate change causes increasingly severe droughts and extreme heat in regions that have historically grown lots of fruits and vegetables such as the American Southwest, California and Central America, experts say it's important that Illinois strengthen its food system. There may even come a time when others look to Illinois — which has a relatively mild climate and ample water supply — to grow what they no longer can.

"Either we have to move water to where the agriculture is or move the agriculture to where the water is," said Jay Famiglietti, a hydrologist, engineer and director at the Arizona Water Innovation Institute. He attributes the water scarcity in the Southwest to climate change.

Decades of intense row crop farming with lots of fertilizer, however, are leaving scars on Illinois soil and polluting local waterways. Meanwhile, the Trump administration is cutting funds to incipient efforts to strengthen local food systems that were gaining momentum under the Biden administration.

Turn to Farms, Page 4

ID portal closed after ICE subpoena

To protect migrants, city clerk suspends site for applications to CityKey program

By Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago city clerk is suspending the online application portal to a municipal ID program recently subpoenaed by U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, the latest defense from local officials grappling with the threat of mass deportations under Republican President Donald Trump.

Clerk Anna Valencia announced Friday that her office would take the CityKey online portal offline Friday night, a week after the Tribune reported that ICE subpoenaed her office for the personal information of applicants to the program that is often used by noncitizens.

The clerk said that while CityKey's in-person events — which do not leave behind a written trail that identifies applicants — will not be affected, her office decided to halt online applications after other elected officials and community groups expressed concern.

"We did hear, 'Let's pause the online platform temporarily as we take a pulse and evaluate what's happening,'" Valencia said during an interview with the Tribune. "We're going to assess what's happening daily and where the climate is, and if we feel we are in a different place, we can easily turn the online platform back on, but we are not going anywhere."

The April 17 subpoena from ICE, which Mayor Brandon Johnson's administration has vowed to resist, represents a new frontier in the president's immigration crackdown that has placed Chicago squarely in his crosshairs. But for those familiar with CityKey, news of the federal government's unprecedented hunt for applicants' personal information raised the question of why there were records to subpoena in the first place.

When the municipal ID launched in 2017 under Valencia

Turn to CityKey, Page 9



When the CityKey municipal ID launched in 2017, officials said the city would not keep identifying documents because the cards would be printed on the spot at in-person events. CHRIS WALKER/
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

INSIDE

At Broadview ICE center, detentions and ankle monitors

Two people who are in immigration proceedings were detained and others received ankle monitors after following instructions to report Sunday for a check-in. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Trump said to have nixed Israeli plan to kill Iranian leader

President Donald Trump rejected a plan presented by Israel to the U.S. to kill Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, according to a U.S. official familiar with the matter. **Nation & World**

Illinois mom pleads with US for Gaza escape

Citizen sues for government's assistance in evacuation, says family lives in 'constant fear'

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

For Salsabeel ElHelou, it's difficult to come up with the words to fully describe the "primitive" living conditions in Gaza for her and her three children. There's no fuel for cooking, she said, and the drinking water is dirty. She spends much of her time desperately searching for flour to make bread because food is so scarce.

ElHelou, an American citizen, said she's unsuccessfully pleaded with the U.S. government since the war broke out about a year and a half ago to help her entire family return to downstate Carbondale, the town where she grew up.

At one point, she said her name and those of her two youngest children appeared on a Rafah border crossing list from Gaza into Egypt, but not her oldest

son. A few months ago, the U.S. Embassy informed ElHelou there was an opportunity for her to exit alone. She stayed in Gaza both times, saying it isn't "logical, mentally sound or humane" for a mother to leave any of her children behind in a war zone. She is estranged from their father, but nevertheless would still never abandon one of them.

"Simply put, I would continue to live in hell wherever I go if I left one of my children in this war," ElHelou, 40, told the Tribune over text messages. "My family's life in Illinois was a fundamen-

tal part of my identity before we moved to Gaza, and I have every right to return to my country and my community there."

Attorneys representing ElHelou argued before a judge earlier this month at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse downtown that the U.S. government has a responsibility to evacuate citizens and some members of their families during times of war or natural disaster.

The June 3 hearing on a request for a preliminary injunction

Turn to Gaza, Page 2

